Knights of the Sky

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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by SomePaperMoons

Summary

Adora rolled her eyes. “You really believe that?”

Catra looked away. “That what? The Horde brings strength and order to Etheria? That we make society stronger? That we have a right to rule the rest of this godsforsaken land? What do you think?”

“I don’t know.”

“Of course, you don’t, you wouldn’t understand.” Catra lay back on the wreckage, not looking at her. “No one ever does.”

Two Fighter Pilots on each side of a brutal conflict find each other in a strange, quiet moment on a piece of wreckage in the ocean.

"Grayskull Leader, this is Thaymor Control, I have some trade for you over Plumeria. Bandits 24 at Angels 1-5 heading North East - East."

"Roger Thaymor Control," Adora replied, keeping an eye on the planes on either side of her. "Grayskulls, turn to port and climb to angels 1-5."

"*Wilco,"* sounded Glimmer.

"*Roger,*" called Bow.

"*Where the hell are the bombers?*" Frosta moaned.

Adora ignored it. "Red two, hold formation, you're lagging behind!"

"*Sorry!*" Seahawk blustered as he pulled his plane into formation behind Mermista's. "*Still not used to these Swift Winds!*"

"Ugh," Mermista groaned. "*You have, like, fifteen hours logged, what's your problem?*"

"Cut the chatter back there," Adora warned, "And keep your eyes out for their bomber stream."

"*I wonder what the target is?*" Perfuma mused.

"*Probably the docks at Seaworthy,*" Bow suggested.

"*They better not hit our airfield again,"* Glimmer growled. "*I'm not spending another night at that bloody flying club."*

Adora sighed. Grayskull Squadron might have one of the highest kills in the entire Rebellion Air Force, but that didn't stop them from being an unruly, messy mob of pilots, both in the air and in the ground. Whether it was Glimmer picking fights with other units, Frosta going on 'Solo patrols' without telling anyone or Seahawk deciding to develop a fire-shooting autocannon, there

was always something chaotic going on. That is if there was time for it. The last week had been the worst week of fighting the Squadron – scratch that, the entire Air Force had ever had. The war was swinging in the Horde's favour and the hammer blows were falling quickly. Since the fall of the Sea Gate and the collapse of the Salinean war effort a month ago, everyone had known that Brightmoon was next.

The Rebellion had braced itself for the next attack, the summer days heavy with anticipation as invasion panic racked the countryside. First, there came attacks on convoys, and raids on coastal towns, but then a week ago, the sky had been filled with Grey, hulking bombers that smashed their runways while the outnumbered RAF flew sortie after sortie to try and down as many Horde planes as they could. Adora had flown more missions in the last week than she had in the last three months of action, and she knew that the same was true for the rest of them. They were exhausted: fighting an enemy that was faceless and remorseless, their endless stream of bombers unloading their deadly payload every hour of daylight every day. But they couldn't stop now. They couldn't break. If they lose grip now, the Horde will control the skies, and then-

Adora didn't want to think about what they'd do if got here. She'd seen enough newsreels and photographs of Horde Soldiers trampling across the rest of Etheria, their Green and Yellow Banners plastered over Dryl Castle and the Sea Gate. People had said 'it couldn't happen here'. Well, now it was.

She looked out and saw the leafy town of Plumeria below her left-wing, sitting picturesquely between two cloudbanks. "Ok Grayskull Squadron, let's find the bombers and get this over with, nothing fancy."

"*What, like diving into the leader of a bomber stream and faking a ram?"* Glimmer snarked. Adora rolled her eyes but focused on scanning the sky.

"*There!*" Frosta shouted. "*In the clouds*!" Adora twisted her neck in the cockpit to see the shape of two dozen boxy, squat Horde Bombers emerging from the clouds below them. They were a recognisable sight now, Silvery-dark grey metal glistened in the sun as they passed out of their cover, their lines boxy and mechanical compared to the smooth curves and graceful lines of a Swift Wind.

Here we go then. "Thaymor Control, this is Grayskull Squadron, engaging target." She was about to begin the turn when the furthest fighter to her left peeled off without warning.

"Frosta-" it was too late now – Frosta's plane was already twisting and turning down and away towards the front of the bomb flight. "Godsdammit. Yellow Wing stay high and keep your eye out for the escorts. The rest of you, with me!"

"Roger!" Mermista replied as she led Seahawk and Perfuma up to cover their attack. *Here we go then,* Adora thought as she pulled her flying goggles down and gunned her engine, peeling away with Glimmer and Bow following her in tight formation, the roar of their engines inaudible over the thunder of hers. "Glimmer-"

"I know, I know, stick to Frosta and cover the front while you and Bow take them from the rear, I've got it!" they were dropping quickly now, the altimeter spinning as Swift Wind dived at near 400 miles an hour, the Horde bombers filling their forward view. The first Horde Gunners had spotted them now, and a few erratic streams of machine-gun fire hissed her direction. Frosta, for her part, had closed the distance quickly enough to avoid the rear gunners and slotted into the blind spot of one of the bombers. Adora was too busy picking her target and lining up to attack to see the first Horde Bomber of the day start belching smoke and drop out of formation, three snow-white parachutes dropping from her fuselage as it spiralled to the ground.

Adora's target had no such luck. She held her steep dive as long as she could before pressing down the trigger, letting fly with eight machine guns into the Bomber's starboard engine. Almost

instantly the engine blew up and the wing folded on itself as her quarry plummeted to the ground in flames, she turned in a tight arc, spotting Bow and Glimmer's targets dropping out of formation as well.

"*Four for four,*" Glimmer said smugly, "*Good start*."

"Don't get cocky yet," Frosta snarked. *"Don't want them to drop bombs on one of mummy's nice palaces, do we?"*

"Focus, people!" Adora yelled, scanning the sky quickly as Glimmer and Bow lined up on two more Bombers, firing steadily in short bursts before breaking away.

"Relax, skipper, there's no fighter cover!" Frosta was bouncing through the bomber stream, putting more fire into the beleaguered beasts. Where were the fighters?

"There!" Mermista warned as a dark shape thundered past Adora the rest of her wing. She spun quickly, spotting the Horde fighter rolling away from her in the corner of her eye. *"12 of them, out of the sun!"*

"Grayskull Squadron, break! Break!" She pulled the steering column towards her, wincing as the plane buffeted against the g forces. Swift Wind levelled out and she turned her back towards the Bomber stream, the remaining machines surrounded by a swarm of duelling fighters.

"*I've got one on me!*" Glimmer warned.

"I'm on them," Frosta yelled. Adora spotted an ailing bomber and swung into position, letting fly for a second as its starboard engine burst into flames and the machine peeled away towards the ground.

"*Got them!*" Frosta yelled. "*Up in smoke!*" The plane in question's belching smoke was visible even from here, as Adora turned to gain height for another attack run.

"Frosta, don't watch it-" suddenly one of the Horde fighters cut straight across the top of Adora, making the Squadron Leader duck as it zeroed in on Frosta. "Frosta, you've got one on you!" The young pilot's plane was still flying in a dead straight line as she watched her kill crash to earth. "Dammit," Adora murmured, pushing her engine forward as she raced after the enemy fighter. "Glimmer, cover me, I'm after the bastard with the red nose."

"Roger Grayskull Leader," Glimmer replied.

The red-nosed fighter – probably the squadron leader - was now practically on top of Frosta. *Too late, too late!* Then at the last, moment, Frosta cut right. "*Gods!*" she yelled. "*There's one of them on me!"* The enemy had barely blinked at the change, turning tightly with her to stay on Frosta's tailed as she dived and spun to evade. For a few seconds, Adora watched them, holding her height, before twisting the stick and pulling Swift Wind into a dive, the engine roaring as she thundered towards the dueling pair. The two planes still bobbed and weaved as Adora closed, forcing her to match their bucking course through the clouds. She was barely 50 metres away when she left fly with her machine guns, not bothering to check if she'd hit before pulling the stick back and forcing Swift Wind into a steep climb. She just had to get the enemy plane off of Frosta, then she could handle them.

"Frosta, are you clear?" There was no answer on the radio. "Frosta?"

"*She's hit,*" Bow replied. "*I think she bailed but*-" he cut off for a second.

Adora grimaced. This Horde Fighter Squadron was giving them a run for their money. They needed to regroup if they were going to manage this, and fast. She was about to put herself into a level flight bullets whipped past the cockpit with alarming accuracy. "Fuck!" she yelled, turning Swift Wind to port as red-nose shot past her before turning tightly to follow her.

"*You've got one on you Grayskull Leader!*" Bow yelled.

"I can manage. Focus on those bombers!" she yelled as she ducked and weaved, grimacing as red-nose matched her uncannily in the wing mirror above her. Red-Nose was doing everything right: They had the height and were forcing Adora closer and closer to the ground where the Swift Wind's agility would be no use. Every time she tried to pull up to gain altitude the *whip-whip* of cannon shell crashing past the cockpit forced her back into her shallow turning dive. As she twisted and turned, she caught glimpses of two parachutes dropping through the sky – one of hers? She hoped so – better to jump and live than burn up. She wondered if she could cut back towards the rest of the squadron, but another burst of fire rattled past her as a warning.

"Fine then, " She murmured, "Let's play then." She pushed Swift Wind into a deeper dive, her forward view of sky replace by the patchwork of Plumerian fields and forests, the Salenian sea visible in the distance. She didn't bother to look back – red nose was obviously following – but pushed further into the dive, the plan dropping steadily like a stone.

4000 feet – 3000 feet – 2000 feet – 1500 – 1000 – Red nose was still following with vicious intent. Adora could see buildings now growing larger and larger.

900-800-700- Adora pulled back, straining against the G Forces as she willed her Swift Wind to do anything but plant straight into the field below them. For his part, the plane responded, levelling out as Adora swooped low over woodland between two villages. She craned her neck round. Where the hell was Red-nose?

There was a crash and then the Horde Fighter swooped overhead. The was a whine from something – her Swift Wind had been hit – but Adora barely noticed as she swung the plane over to following pushing her complaining engine further and further to catch up. Red-Nose was being cocky now, waggling their wings back at her as they raced away, but Adora was matching them, and they'd burned all their speed from the dive in a boastful, wide turn to watch Adora's supposed demise. *Not anytime soon,* she thought. The Horde plane closed into her sights, and she pressed her

thumb on the trigger. Instantly Red-nose twisted left, a few bullets glanced off their tail as Adora turned to match. They were nearly over the sea now, but Red-Nose showed no sign of giving up, ducking and weaving as Adora spat bullets at them.

She was nearly out of ammunition now: 8 seconds seemed like so much in training, but it was barely enough in a dogfight – but she pressed Swift Wind to the edge, feeling him strain against the acceleration. She glanced and saw the chunks missing in her left wing and the white smoke billowing back but shrugged it off. "Come, on, come on," she growled, pushing herself further. There was a buffeting lurch as they flew over the cliffs and away from land, but Red-Nose was still matching her speed. Adora glanced at her fuel gauge, grimacing at how low the needle had dropped. But if she was suffering, so was Red Nose, and they could afford to waste fuel on fancy manoeuvres even less than she could.

Red Nose was obviously not on the same page, however, as they cut right in a stalling turn towards Adora, but she was expecting it, twisting right, pulling her steering column as far as she could. "Come on!" she yelled as her Swift Wind groaned, but then Red Nose was in her sights, and her machine guns rattled away as a great belch of smoke lurched from the Horde Fighter. It turned away slowly, losing speed as it began to stutter. "Yes!" Adora yelled, turning with her to watch her pilot get out, but then there was a crash and she looked to see that the smoke hissing from her engine had turned a menacing black.

Damn. She glanced around, not seeing whether Red-Nose had ditched or not. She glanced down – too low to jump. Sighing, she cut her engine and turned in towards the sea. She pushed her canopy, the sea breeze buffeting her as it rushed past it canopy. It was eerily quiet without the constant roar of the engine, and as she dropped closer and closer to the sea, she could hear the roar of the waves. She was very close to the surface now. It was calm by the standards of the Salinean Sea (if Seahawk was to be believed) – good weather for ditching, if there ever was. She glanced down at her life vest, looked back up, and there the sea was, 20 feet, 10 feet, 5 feet-

There was a crash, and Adora was buffeted as the fighter lurch against the swell, skimming a few dozen meters before crashing to a halt. Instantly, she was out of her seat and clambering onto the fuselage, her Logbook and a flare gun already shoved into her flying jacket. Adora looked around for a second – she had time before Swift Wind began to sink. She spotted a distant coastal town, nodding to herself – someone would have seen her come down, thank god- but then paused. *Where* was red-nose?

The swell shifted suddenly, and the shape of a ditched Horde Fighter rolled into sight about 60 yards away. It looked like it'd gone down harder than Swift Wind had, bits of wreckage floating around in the blue sea. Was the pilot alive? Adora craned her head to see and spotted a gloved hand waving around from a gap in the canopy. The Blonde paused, unsure what to do. Were they signalling? She glanced around, worried a Horde seaplane had found them before a Rebellion Naval Boat could pick them up. There were no planes. What were they playing at? Were they signalling to *her?*

She was about to wave back like an idiot when she noticed the hand grasping at something on the canopy, pulling at a release with frustration. Adora stilled for a second, the wind dropping as she realised the implications. The only thing that was worse than burning up in your own cockpit was drowning in it while your plane sunk beneath the waves, with no one to know what had happened to you.

Instantly she jumped off her Swift Wind and into the water. She hissed and froze up for a second as she icy coldness hit her, but she pushed through, kicking her legs and pulling herself through the waves as she swam towards the enemy fighter. Every peak obscured the plane from view, and every time she panicked, worried that it had been pulled under and her pilot with her, but every time it reappeared her nose slowly sinking, the pilot still desperately trying to push her canopy back.

The water was freezing, her uniform soaked through, her muscles ached with the strain, but Adora swam on until she was up close

to the plane now, the Yellow and Green Horde Recognition flash on the port wing blackened with smoke, the kill markers on the nose stripped away by bullet holes – bullets fired by Adora. The Canopy was barely above the surface, and as Adora hauled herself onto the nose cowling she could see water pooling around the Pilot's shoulders as they continued ramming a tool into the canopy. Suddenly they looked up at her, face still obscured by a flight helmet and the glare of the sun.

They yelled something that Adora couldn't hear. "Hold on!" She yelled back. She looked around for something to get some purchase on the canopy, finding only the empty sea around her. She grimaced. "Watch out!" She yelled, then steadied herself before kicking her boot into the canopy. She jolted back for a second, nearly falling off the stricken aircraft before she caught her balance. Water was lapping at her feet now. She didn't have much time.

Adora braced herself then kicked at the glass canopy again. She almost fell again as it finally slid back with a crash but gathered herself as she clambered forward and thrust a hand into the cockpit. "Come on!" she yelled. The Horde Pilot looked at her for a second, aghast. "You got another plan?" Adora shot back. The Pilot stared at her, then put a hand up and Adora hauled them out of the cockpit just as water came in the sides. There was a second where the Horde Plane sat level, then both pilots were lurched to one side as it was pulled under the water. They both fell in, Adora coming up for air and immediately looking around to see where Red-Nose's pilot had gone. She twisted her head to see the scrabbling in their lifejacket.

Adora looked around to see a bit of a wing floating in the water. It looked stable enough to hold onto. She started to swim for it, gesturing for Red-Nose to follow. They did so, at a far slower rate, their swimming erratic and strained. Adora had already propped herself up on the large wing panel by the time they arrived, and they gave her an irritable glare. "You're on my plane."

Adora stared at them for a second. "…ok?" The pilot looked at her for a second expectantly. "Do you want a hand up, or-"

"I'll be fine," they muttered back as they pulled themselves onto the wreckable with some difficulty, wincing as they rolled onto the wing.

Adora watched them as they sat up, rocking slightly with the swell, and pulled their flying helmet off, revealing a head of short hair and two mismatched, irritated eyes of deep blue and golden yellow. They were lean, but not in the ill-fed manner of a Horde Conscript, but trimmer, with a black leather jacket worn over dark flying overalls and black boots. She was- well, she was-

"What are you looking at?" she glowered at Adora. "Never seen a Horde pilot before?"

"I – well, no, actually I was- you're wounded." She pointed to the red stain on the Horde Pilot's right leg.

The pilot looked down at it, grimaced, then sighed. "I'll be fine, Princess."

Adora frowned. "Princess?"

The enemy pilot nodded. "That's you, isn't it? The Princesses? I thought I recognised that stupid Sword on your plane."

"We're not the *Princesses,*" Adora shot back. "We're Grayskull Squadron."

"Yeah, the Princesses." The dark-haired pilot added with a sneer. "You know, cos you've got the Queen's daughter up their playing toy soldiers?"

"Hey, now, Glimmer is *not* playing around," Adora snarked. "She's just another pilot, like the rest of us."

"Oh yeah, sure, that's why she's Squadron Leader after less than a year in the service."

“I’m Squadron Leader,” Adora said with an eye roll. “Sure, Glimmer’s my Number 2, but she got that job because she’s *good* not because her mum is – you know, the Queen or anything.”

“What about you then?” The Pilot glared at her with a cocky smile. “You a Duke’s Daughter? Daddy an MP or something? Who’d he call to get you a top job?”

“No one,” Adora growled back. “I don’t even have any parents. It’s just me.”

“Oh,” The Horde pilot said quietly. “I’m sorry.” They looked away for a second, watched a bird bob on the surface a few yards away.

“It’s fine,” Adora said less heatedly. There were a few minutes of silence as they sat there in silence. “I’m Adora, by the way,” she eventually said, putting a hand out to be shaken.

The Horde pilot looked back at her, eyeing her up with her deep mismatched eyes. “Catra,” she eventually said, shaking Adora’s hand firmly.

***

“So,” Adora began, “Why did you join up?”

Catra snorted. “You don’t join up in the Horde. If you’re lucky, you get a letter through the door telling you to report within 12 hours. If you’re unlucky, you pulled off the street and chucked in a van with every other military-age person who was stupid enough to be out after curfew.”

“Oh.” Adora fiddled with her hands for a second. “What was it for you?”

Catra glowered at her. “I got a card through my door about three days before the war began.” She shrugged. “Didn’t have many choices. What about you? Stirred by Patriotism? Called to arms by Queen Angella? Like the look of the fancy uniform?”

Adora looked down at her sodden blue uniform, her unkempt Uniform Jacket with its tattered undone belt and chuckled, before shaking her head. "I'm a Pre-War regular. Been in it for what, three years?" She thought for a second, remembering when she'd turned up to the recruiting office in Brightmoon, scrawny and unkempt, the look of amusement on the Flight Sergeant's face turning to astonishment when she handed him her finished exam after a mere ten minutes. "It was something to do, I suppose. I didn't have the money for college. I was good at it."

"Lucky you," Catra growled. "So you joined before it got all flashy then?"

"Flashy?" Adora cocked her head. "Oh, yeah, we were an odd sort back then before they started giving us all the equipment we wanted. I did my first year in the service flying plodding Biplanes like the Kowl- oh, you wouldn't know, the Kowl-"

"Single-engine biplane, with a maximum speed of 280 Miles per hour, armed with four .303 machine guns. Slow, but very manoeuvrable." She gave Adora a knowing smile. "You'd think you'd get a better plane for the princesses, wouldn't you?"

"Oh, they were fine," Adora snarked. "Nothing like a Swift Wind though." Catra snorted. "What?"

"That pile of junk? Fancy wings and a big engine don't make a good fighter. Now the ME-Log, that's a plane for warriors."

Adora gave her a cocky smile. "Is that why we're sitting on a piece of yours then?"

Catra scowled. "You got lucky."

"*You* followed me down when you should've gone back and looked after your bombers," Adora pointed out.

"Oh please, I'm not taking tactical advice from the person who sent their fighters in piece by piece."

“Hey! That wasn’t the plan!”

“You had a plan?”

Adora scowled at the sneering tone. “Of course we have a plan! We always have a plan.” She sighed bitterly. “Following it, though…”

Catra chuckled. “Princesses hard to keep in line?”

“They’re good pilots, they can handle themselves, but…they don’t really know what discipline means. They think it’s all about heroics and guts and glory, then back down to base to party all night before they do it again in the morning.” Adora paused, leaning back slightly to look back at the sky, where the vapours trails from today’s air battle were dissipating in the afternoon breeze. “I get it. They don’t know whether this scramble will be there last. Whether this time, the Horde fighter on their tail is the one that’ll send them spinning to the ground in flames. They can’t think ahead – they don’t want to, but-“

“You wish they’d care enough about their lives to actually keep them,” Catra finished for them. “I get it. We-“she paused for a second, her expression distant as she ran her tongue long her lips, thinking. “We go through a lot of young kids back at base. Fresh out of flight school, with no more than 2,3 hours of ME-Logs, going up to face your lot still wet behind the ears.” She sighed. “Every night we sit back down at base, and there’s another empty plate and-“ Catra swore, smacking a hand into the metal skin of the wing. “Every time I tell command we need more time to train, but every day we go back up and I have to watch more of them go down in flames!”

Adora watched Catra as she slumped, defeated. “I’m sorry.”

Catra twisted, a cruel grimace on her face. “Are you?”

“Why wouldn’t I be?”

“We’re the enemy. We’re trying to crush you. We’ve already ground Salineas into the dust, now we’re trying to destroy Brightmoon from the air. We’re bombing your cities, smashing your airfields, killing *your* friends. You should hate us!” Catra’s glared was fixed on hers now, and Adora could see the haunted, gaunt tiredness behind them now.

“All death is loss, Catra,” Adora replied. “Every life is valuable. Every single one. The Horde might not think that, but we do.”

“You really believe that crap?” The Horde Pilot sneered at her. “That you’re fighting for freedom? For Justice? For the rights of the downtrodden everywhere? You must be more naïve than I thought.”

“Why not? You said it yourself. You-the Horde- you’re just after power, and control. You conquered Scorpio and Salineas and subjugated their people. You throw your own citizens to die in their droves, for what? So you can prove that your Order is better than our Liberty?”

“It *is*,” Catra growled. “And for the record, The Scorpio were annexed after they voted to join the horde.”

Adora rolled her eyes. “You really believe that?”

Catra looked away. “That what? The Horde brings strength and order to Etheria? That we make society stronger? That we have a *right* to rule the rest of this godsforsaken land?” She turned back and met Adora’s eyes again, her expression still haunted. “What do you think?”

“I don’t know.”

“Of course, you don’t, you wouldn’t understand.” Catra lay back on the wreckage, not looking at her. “No one ever does.”

***

It was Catra who spoke again, after another 20 minutes bobbing about in the sea. “What would you be doing? If you weren’t in the Air Force, I mean.”

Adora shrugged. “I don’t know. I didn’t really have many options. In an ideal world, I went to college. But the world isn’t ideal, so I’m a soldier.”

Catra turned her head to look at her. “You don’t look like you like that idea.”

“It’s all I’ve ever known. And I like service. I like giving something back – being useful. I hate being useless. Powerless.” Adora sighed.

“I get the feeling,” Catra said with a sigh. “The powerlessness, I mean. Less the ‘service to the state’ crap.”

Adora chuckled. “What about you, then? What would you be doing?”

“If I wasn’t floating on half a wing in the Salinean sea?” Catra smiled wistfully. “I’d be back in Halfmoon, finishing my Art Degree.”

Adora crooked an eyebrow, smiling deviously. “I didn’t peg you for an artist.”

“No one ever does,” she said with an equally devious smile. “My mother certainly didn’t. She wanted me to be soldier or a politician. Preferably both.” The light from Catra’s eyes, the light that danced in the summer afternoon glow vanished for a second.

Adora leant in. “What did you paint? Landscapes?”

“Landscapes?” Catra snorted. “Do I look like a dullard?” She chuckled at Adora’s sheepish look. “Relax, I’m not angry. I sculpted. People. Scenes. Abstract concepts. I liked working with my hands. Making things.” The Horde pilot sighed as she stared at her gloved hands for a second, and Adora could almost see them

covered with clay instead of leather, the haggard woman next to her clothed in the loose shirt and apron of an artist she'd once seen in a film. "Now I just use them for killing."

Adora smiled hopefully. "Not forever, though. War has to end, doesn't it?"

"Not anytime soon," Catra growled. "Your lot are not exactly about to march into the Fright Zone are they?"

"No, but it could swing the other way," Adora said, earning a crooked eyebrow from Catra. "Not that I'd want that to happen, really, but it could."

"I doubt it," Catra replied. "We're running out of planes. Out of pilots. We burned through our best in Salineas, and thought you'd come to the table then." Adora snorted at the idea. "Yeah, that's what I thought to, but Hordak -well, he's not one for listening to reason, so now we're meant to smash you from the sky and look how well that's going." Catra sighed. "No, this war is going to last a long time, and when it's over the Horde's going to have lost and lost badly."

Adora watched Catra as she lay there in silence, unperturbed by her prediction of her Mother Country's downfall. She seemed more resigned to it than anything. "Well then," Adora began, "when the war is over, you'll have to show me some of that art of yours."

Catra seemed not to believe her. "Sure."

"No, no," Adora said earnestly. "When this is over, you'll put an art show on, and I'll turn up and tell everyone loudly how I met the great artist Catra, winner of all awards, sitting on a piece of metal in the ocean. I'll make sure to remind them that I shot you down."

"Oh please," Catra snorted. "I knocked your Swift Wind out first. You just got lucky."

"Hey!"

“I’m not wrong.” Adora pouted at her. “Don’t worry. I’ll name a sculpture after you or something. I’ll call it…the flying dork.”

“That seems mean.”

“Do you want a sculpture or not?” Catra said slyly.

Adora lay back on the wing slowly, sliding her head to look across at the enemy pilot who stared back at her with an enigmatic look of interest. “From you? Of course I do.”

***

“Ours or yours?” Adora craned her neck up, following the buzz of an aircraft engine, frowning up at the late afternoon sky.

“Yours, I think,” she said eventually.

“A recuse plane?” Catra asked, the hope in her voice poorly masked.

“I…no. Looks like a bomber.” Adora squinted again. “One engine out, limping home.”

“God fucking-“ Catra grunted, “fuck!”

“It’ll be fine,” Adora muttered. “Someone will find us eventually.”

“I’m not sure I’ll be around then.”

Adora turned round, looking in horror at her companion’s suddenly pale, sallow face. “Catra!” She reached out for the bandage on her log, her eyes widening when it came back wet and matted red. “Why didn’t you say anything!”

“It…wasn’t your problem,” she gasped back. “Besides, it’s not your job to keep me alive. If anything, you’ve got to make *sure* I die.”

“Don’t say things like that!” Adora growled as she pulled her jackets off, feeling the chill of the sea breeze she ripped one of her sleeves up. “That doesn’t matter now.”

"Of course it does," Catra said through gritted teeth. "This is war. Every action counts, and now – now you've got to live. And I've got to die. I know that. I'm okay with it."

"Bullshit," Adora muttered. "You've got a life to finish having."

"W-what are you doing?" Catra was struggling to sit up now as Adora lifted her leg up and began binding the wound with her ripped sleeve.

"Trying to save your life!"

"Why bother! I told you, Adora, I'm done!" Catra tried to lean in to yell at her, instead groaning with pain and falling back onto the metal of the wing. "Don't…try. No one's going to miss me."

"*I'm* going to miss you," the blonde hissed back as she tried to clean the blood off her hands.

"Why? You've known me for three hours, and before that, you were trying to kill me? We aren't friends. We're enemies."

"We're in this together, Catra. And I'm not letting you accept your fate." Adora looked around desperately, willing a boat or a plane or *anything* to appear on the horizon. "You're not done yet."

"I wish I'd gotten to see my first show," Catra breathed. "My first proper show. It was scheduled for two days after the war began. Everything was ready. It was…work in metal. Twisted steel and aluminium that's I'd been working for years on. They were soldiers…caught in the moment of death. Twisted, torn, agonised. It was very dramatic. I loved it." Catra sighed, her breath whistling slightly with the strain. "It all got melted down for the war effort. Made into bullets. Almost poetic, isn't it."

"I'm sorry."

Catra turned her head slowly, her glazed eyes focusing eventually on Adora's face. "It's just metal. I just…" she laughed, coughing slightly as she did. "I worked so much energy into it and it's just

gone. So much energy into showing *death* and now, I'm just dying…like this." She waved a hand down her body. "Slowly. Pointlessly."

"You're not dying. Not here, not right now."

"Don't lie to me, Adora."

"I'm *not!* I won't give up on you. I won't let myself. I'm gonna get you to safety even if I have to swim across the whole Salenian sea!"

"For me?"

"Who else?"

Catra blinked up at her. "Why do you care? I don't matter! I'm just an enemy pilot."

"You matter to *me,*" Adora persisted, grabbing Catra's shoulders and holding her tenderly. "I don't- you just, do, okay. I just know you do. Just- just hang on. Someone's gonna come. I know they will." There was a buzz in the air, low and guttural, and Catra craned her neck upwards.

"Ours or yours?" she gasped sardonically.

Adora twisted her head round. "No, that's a boat." She blinked. "That's a boat! Catra! We're saved!"

"Are we?" Catra didn't seem to believe it.

"Yeah!" Adora was up on her feet now, standing carefully to balance herself carefully on the wing as she began waving furiously at the distant motor launch. "It's turning towards us!"

"Is..is it ours or yours?" Catra said, grunting as she sat up.

"Erm-" Adora squinted, looking for the dark green flash of the Horde flag. "I can't-"

“It’s yours,” Catra said quietly. “I can tell from the engine.”

“What?” Adora frowned at her despondence “What’s wrong with that?”

“I’m your prisoner now,” she growled. “That’s my war over. If I’m not dead in a day.”

“Bullshit,” Adora said smiling. “You’ll be fine. The war will end soon and I can get that sculpture you promised me.”

“Sure, sure,” she gasped. “You’ll get that sculpture. I’ll make sure of it.” There was a beat of silence, and then Catra let out a long sigh. “Adora?”

“Yes, Catra?”

“I’ll see you soon.” Adora looked back and Catra’s eyes were closed.

“Catra!” Adora dropped to her knees, grabbing her and shaking her. “No! No no no no no!” There was no response. “You can’t go now. Not now! Not when we were so close!”

The boat was alongside them now, bobbing slowly through the sea until it was beside the pair. “Come on, miss!” A voice yelled from the boat. Adora blinked, then looked up into the eyes of a sailor. “Leave the Horde pilot, she’s a goner!”

“Not yet!” Adora shot back. “Take her first, and get a medic!”

The sailor frowned. “What?”

“Take her!” Adora lifted Catra’s unconscious body with all her might and heaved it up until the sailor above her grabbed the horde pilot and hauled her onto the deck, before offering Adora his hand to pull her up onto the deck. Adora pushed past him immediately, lifting Catra’s body again and carrying her over to the back deck of the motor launch and laying her on the flat deck.

She pressed her ear to Catra's chest, sighing with relief when she heard the thump of a heartbeat.

"Sir, you should get below," a voice called.

"Where's the medic?" Adora hissed.

"On their way, sir."

"I'll stay here until they come." Adora looked up to see the sailor and the boat's skipper watching her. "Is that going to be a problem?"

The skipper and the sailor looked at each other for a second. "No, sir," the skipper said. Adora nodded at him curtly as a dismissal.

"Good."

There was the sound of footsteps on the deck and then Adora saw someone drop to their knees next to Catra's body. "Where was she hit?"

"Left leg, thigh wound," Adora heard herself say. The medic nodded, quickly cutting away Adora's sleeve and dressing the wound properly. "Will she live?"

"I can't say, she's lost a lot of blood," the medic replied. "We'll be back at Seaworthy soon; we can make a proper assessment then." Adora felt an arm on her shoulder "Don't get your hopes up though, sir."

"She'll make it," Adora replied determinedly. "She will. She's got things to do." She lay there for a while longer, the medic kneeling beside her. Eventually, she sat up properly, facing out away from Catra to look out at the sea. The sun sat low in the sky now, its reflection dancing low across the golden sea in the evening light. The wreckage of their planes was long gone now, lost the gloom of the evening light. Adora reached back and undid her ponytail, letting her hair drop to sit on her shoulders, running her hand through it. She had never felt this exhausted in her entire life, and

as she watched the cliffs of Seaworthy pass in front her, she wondered what she'd do if Catra didn't make it. Six hours ago, she hadn't known this person even existed, but now? How could she let her go when she barely knew anything about her – what she did when she had free time, how she worked, what made her laugh and what made her cry. Adora wondered how she'd go on. Would she? How could she?

Suddenly, she heard coughing from behind her and twisted to see Catra turning over on her side, blinking.

"Catra?" Adora breathed.

The Horde pilot grinned. "Hey, Adora."

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